Course Outline Template

Indian Institute of Management Calcutta

Programme :…MBA……

Name of the Course: **Signs, Symbols and Codes in Marketing**

Core / Elective -……Elective…….Cap (for Elective)…….

Credit: …….

Academic Year & Term: ……..

Course Coordinator: ……..

Email: IIMC id:

Instructor: ……..(Sessions … – …)

Affiliation: ……..

Email: IIMC id:

Instructor: ……..(Sessions … – …)

Affiliation: ……..

Email: IIMC id:

Introduction to Course /Course Description

"People buy things not only for what they can do, but also for what they mean." Sidney J. Levy (1959)

Signs and symbols are all around us, and no one can escape their power. Symbols are the language of advertising, religion, art, literature, and theatre and are saturated with emotion. Some of the most effective forms of persuasion in our world today work not at the level of explicit arguments or facts, but at the level of signs and symbols: at the level of ideology.

In this course we look at the use of signs and symbols as a means of communication and meaning-making. This is vital in the science of marketing communications, advertising and branding. This course would be useful for students learning how to refocus, extend or reposition a brand, or in developing new products or new markets. It will also help students learn how to create clear and impactful brand communication as well as find relevant communication channels for the target market.

The course focuses on hands-on learning and will include practical exercises in branding, consumer culture, advertising, design and services.

Course Objective and Key-takeaways from the course

After completing this course, the participants would be able to:

1. Understand how visual cues influence consumer perception and brand meaning across different cultural contexts.
2. Learn how to decode brand messages and advertising content to uncover deeper layers of meaning.
3. Critically analyze the deeper meaning behind brands, their communications, packaging and design

Programme Level Learning Goals

1.	Possess state-of-the-art knowledge of theory and practice in all functional fields of management and the ability to think critically, and apply them to diagnose and find solutions to organisational problems, even in unfamiliar or uncertain situations
2.	Develop a global perspective that is built upon knowledge of economic, technological, regulatory and political forces that are shaping a new international order in the 21st century
3.	Develop their capacity to articulate their thinking and ideas through verbal and written communications, at a professional (manager/consultant) level and to deliver the same
4.	Acquire capacity to apply their professional knowledge and skills to diagnose and resolve business problems in actual organizational settings
5.	Acquire the leadership qualities and the competence needed for leading organizational change

Goal 1	Goal 2	Goal 3	Goal 4	Goal 5
Critical Thinking a, b, c, d, e	Acquiring Global Perspective a, b, c, d,	Ability to Articulate a, b, c, d, e	Problem Solving a, b, c, d,	Leadership Qualities a, b, c, d,
(a,b,c,d,e)	(b,c,d)	(a,b,c,d,e)	(a,b,c,d)	(c,d)

International Components in your course (if any)

The course provides a vast exposure to the international branding world. Class discussions involve not only global, iconic brands like McDonald's, Starbucks, Coca-Cola and Apple but also lesser-known international brands like Woodbury, Real Cheese, Kraft, WaterAid, Pret A Manger etc. Students decode international advertisements by brands like Audi, Mitsubishi and PETA.

Class discussion topics include the NASA space program, the global diaper industry, men's cosmetics industry and the association between Coca Cola and Santa Claus. Political discussions can revolve around the American Flag, Obama's Hope Campaign, the Arab Spring and Che Guevara. We look at international retail spaces designed by Nike, Google and Decathlon etc.

Pre-requisites

- An understanding of theoretical concepts from Managerial Communication 1 and 2.
- Clear understanding of marketing and branding concepts

Required Text Book(s)

- Laura R. Oswald. Doing Semiotics: A research guide for marketers at the edge of culture. Oxford University Press, 2020. First Edition. ISBN: 9780198862116

Course Pack Distribution to students

Course material (if required) will also be issued from the Programme office

Technology enabled learning component for your course

Students are required to carry laptops for all classes. All sessions will include a practical exercise (either group or individual) based on the day's lecture.

Session Plan

S. No.	Topic	Intended learning outcome	References
1.	**Introduction** • Signs, symbols and meaning making • The symbolic nature of consumption • Products as language **Class Exercise:** Classification and designing of brand logos	Students will be able to appreciate how symbolism can be applied in branding and marketing as a whole. At the end of the session they will be able to identify and design brand logos based on different types of signs.	# Symbols for sale, Levy, HBR, 1959 # Text Book: Chapter 4
2.	**The hidden language of brands** • Brand Equity and semiotic value • Brand Value pyramid **Class Exercise**: Brand Mood Board	Students will learn how brands communicate in different ways (e.g., pricing, products, innovation, customer service, positioning strategy etc.). Through the class exercise, they will learn how to identify intangible brand associations evoked by visual elements.	# Text Book: Chapter 1 # Videos: IBM vs Mac Coke and Santa Claus
3.	**The hidden language of brands** • Brand Rhetoric vs Advertising Rhetoric ○ How brands use rhetoric to build long-term value ○ Metaphors & metonymies in brand communications • Brand System • Brand Naming Techniques • Brand roadmap	In this lecture, students will learn different ways to build on brand rhetoric, which is important for value creation, brand building and brand engagement. In the practical exercise, they will learn how to conduct a historical audit of a brand and strategically present its road map.	# Text Book: Chapter 2 # Videos: Pepsi Coca Cola

4.	**Brand Audit** • Student Presentations	Students will conduct research on the brand's historical advertising (last 5-10 years) to find recurring brand codes. They will note the evolution of the brand system and positioning strategy.	
5.	**Case Study:** • Finding a Cultural Strategy for My Tea **Class Assignment:** Creating a brand map	A real-world case study that will explain how to analyze a product category and the concerned brand. In the class assignment, they will visually present the positioning strategy of a brand, along with its competitors. They will learn to identify gaps in the market, based on visual analysis.	# Case: Finding a Cultural Strategy for My Tea Video: The danger of a single story
6.	**Brand Communication & Advertising** • Advertising strategy • Advertising meaning and Reference • Advertising rhetoric **Case Study**: Instant Gourmet Coffee	Students will understand how to look at advertising from the larger context of culture. The case study demonstrates how advertising strategy focusing on creative appeal is not enough, if it is not relevant to the brand's historical positioning.	# The Morality of Advertising- Levitt, HBR, 1970 #Case: Instant Gourmet Coffee (Laura R. Oswald. Creating Value: OUP, 2015- Pg. 47)
7.	**Product & Packaging Design** • Design in Cultural Perspective • Consumer-centered design • Decoding meaning in packaging • Design of environments	This session focuses on design of things and environments. We study design from a product and packaging perspective as well as retail environments.	# Text Book: Chapter 3
8.	**Brand Packaging Audit** **Class Exercise:** • Brand Packaging Audit	Critical analysis of visual and formal elements of product packaging. Learning how to classify data into discrete, functional categories. Making practical and actionable recommendations for real-life brand scenarios.	
9.	**Servicescape Design** • Material dimensions • Conventional dimensions • Contextual dimensions • Performative dimensions	Here the focus is on the design of retail spaces and service outlets. Students will be able to compare and contrast different design ideas based on architecture. In the class exercise, they will undertake	# Retail Shopping Mall- Langhrehr 1991, ACR

	Class Exercise: Coffee Kiosk in a mall	collaborative effort to critically solve a problem.	
10.	**Group Presentations**	Students will present a cohesive analysis of the brand exercises done in class and given as home assignments. This will represent the entire research process as a case study for their chosen brands. This exercise will build effective communication skills and collaborative mindset.	

Evaluation Components

✓ Components	✓ Weightage
Class Participation	20%
Assignments	20%
End term exam	30%
Group Presentations	30%

Online Course Management (moodle)/course web

This outline may be filled after reading the MBA Instructors Manual

Class/Home Exercises: Learning Objectives

S. No.	Details	Learning Objective
1.	Designing brand logos based on classification of signs: Student chooses a product category and designs 3 logos for a new brand, using each of the 3 categories of signs	Application of theoretical knowledge and ability to think critically.
2.	Brand Mood Board: Choose an iconic, global brand and create a mood board for it.	Brainstorm and identify intangible associations evoked by a brand's intangible elements and represent them visually
3.	Brand Audit: Research the brand's historical advertising (last 5-10 years) to find recurring brand codes. Note the evolution of the brand system and positioning strategy.	Learning how to conduct desktop research and analyze codes in marketing. Presentations to be made in front of peers.
4.	Brand Map: Create a perceptual map on a 2 by 2 axes, using binary codes based on the brand audit conducted in the previous session.	Visual presentation of the positioning strategy of a brand, along with its competitors. Identifying gaps in the market based on visual analysis.
5.	Brand Packaging Audit: Conduct a packaging design audit of the shower category (bath soaps, shower gels etc.). Develop a design concept for the launch of a new brand.	Critical analysis of visual and formal elements of product packaging. Learning how to classify data into discrete, functional categories. Making practical and actionable recommendations for real-life brand scenarios.
6.	Coffee Kiosk in a mall: Design an on-the-go service kiosk for the atrium of an upscale mall.	Application of theoretical concepts (dimensions of retail-space) in the practical world. Critical and strategic thinking.

Reference Document

Aim & Objectives of the Post Graduate Programme: The overall goal of the MBA is to produce world-class management professionals with a global perspective who are competent to lead and transform organisations anywhere in the world. . Our students would:

Learning Goals

1. **Possess state-of-the-art knowledge of theory and practice in all functional fields of management and the ability to think critically, and apply them to diagnose and find solutions to organisational problems, even in unfamiliar or uncertain situations**

Learning Objectives
Our students would be able to : a. Attain theoretical and practical understanding of the functions and processes involved in managing an organization b. Develop critical thinking ability through analytical treatment of important contemporary problems and issues c. Acquire the ability to design approaches and use relevant models and tools to analyse situations and solve practical business problems d. Acquire the ability to persuasively recommend managerial solutions issuing from the process of decision analysis applied on managerial situation/s e. Acquire the ability to present a structured analysis of managerial situation/s using various strands of interpretations

2. Develop and apply ethical values to analyse and solve organisational problems

Learning Objectives
Our students would be able to : a. Understand the realm of ethics (morality, values, ethos) and its importance to society b. Understand the issues of ethical importance specific to the domain of business c. Understand the role of manager/leader as an ethical individual and as a professional d. Understand the need and importance of institutionalizing Ethics within the organization e. Develop an understanding of corporation's duty to all the stakeholders f. Acquire the ability to appreciate the necessity of ethical practices for sustainable growth and profitability

3. Develop a global perspective that is built upon knowledge of economic, technological, regulatory and political forces that are shaping a new international order in the 21st century

Learning Objectives
Our students would be able to : a. Familiarize with global factors/phenomenon affecting the business scenario b. Acquire the ability to understand and comprehend issues and practices prevalent in the international arena c. Develop competence in analysing changes in international and domestic environment d. Respond to such changes through appropriate organizational decisions

4. Develop their capacity to articulate their thinking and ideas through verbal and written communications, at a professional (manager/consultant) level and to deliver the same

Learning Objectives
Our students would be able to : a. Acquire the ability to organize the thought process b. Demonstrate understanding of main points c. Acquire the ability to articulate the findings in a coherent and structured format to build a managerial case analysis d. Acquire the ability to customize messages/ solutions for diverse managerial situations e. Acquire the ability to deliver a professional quality formal presentation by exhibiting clarity and appropriate pace, coherent structure, credibility, effective use of visual aids, appropriate body language

5. Be able to appreciate the dynamics of Information Technology acquisition and absorption by present day business organizations and develop ability to use modern IT enabled decision support tools for improved understanding of business

Learning Objectives
Our students would be able to : a. Acquire the ability to learn various IT-enabled analytical tools , techniques and methods for solving problems b. Acquire familiarity of methods for comparing different state-of-the-art computing platforms c. Acquire the ability to use appropriate analytical techniques in a case setting to identify possibilities of deploying Information Technology for competitive advantage d. Acquire competence in use of IT tools in modelling managerial decision making situations

6. Acquire capacity to apply their professional knowledge and skills to diagnose and resolve business problems in actual organizational settings

Learning Objectives
Our students would be able to : a. Acquire the ability to identify organizational problems in both real life settings and through simulated situations b. Acquire the ability to interpret and apply knowledge of concepts c. Acquire the ability to design appropriate responses to solve identified problems by using appropriate tools, techniques & framework taught in courses d. Acquire the ability to apply structured analytical thinking to solve an organizational problem

7. Acquire the leadership qualities and the competence needed for leading organizational change

Learning Objectives
Our students would be able to : a. Understand the theories of leadership b. Understand the theories of organizational change c. Demonstrate understanding of complex human issues arising from the implementation of change d. Understand individuals' and groups' behavior and motivation

Hypothetical Example of mapping for Operations Research with Programme Level Goals

Goal 1	Goal 2	Goal 3	Goal 4	Goal 5	Goal 6	Goal 7
Critical Thinking a, b, c, d, e	Acquiring Ethical Values a, b ,c ,d, e ,f	Acquiring Global Perspective a, b, c, d,	Ability to Articulate a, b, c, d, e	Technological Competencies a, b, c, d,	Problem Solving a, b, c, d,	Leadership Qualities a, b, c, d,
Operations Research (a,b,c,d,e)					Operations Research (a,b,c,)	

Please note,

- This is hypothetically done just to provide an example
- A course can match multiple Goals
- A course might not meet **all the** objectives, please feel free to identify the objectives that a course might meet